

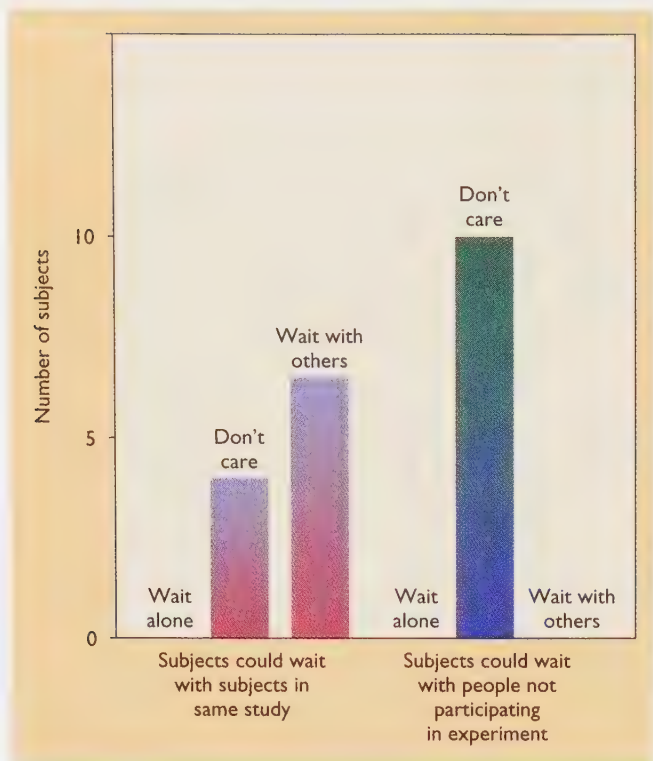


FIGURE 14.7 In Schachter's experiment, people who thought they were waiting for a procedure in which they would receive strong shocks preferred to wait with others who were about to undergo the same procedure. They had no particular desire to wait with people who were not participating in the same study. That is, miserable people like to be with other miserable people. In more general terms, we like to compare our reactions to those of other people who have had, or expect to have, similar experiences.

facing a similar predicament. As the old saying goes, "Misery loves company." To test this hypothesis, Stanley Schachter (1959) told subjects that he intended to measure the effects of electric shock on their heart rate and blood pressure. He told one group to expect substantial shocks; he told the other group to expect mild tickling or tingling sensations. Then, he told the subjects that they would have to wait about 10 minutes while the experimenter made some last-minute adjustments to the equipment. Some subjects were given a choice between waiting alone or waiting with other subjects in the same experiment. Other subjects were given a choice between waiting alone and waiting with students who just happened to be in the building (not subjects in the experiment). Subjects who expected only mild shocks had little preference; they were willing to wait anywhere or with anybody. But the subjects who expected strong shocks strongly preferred to wait with other subjects in the same experiment, as Figure 14.7 shows. In short, people in distress crave the company of people in similar distress. That is, misery loves *miserable* company. Short-term relationships like these can serve a variety of purposes, even if they do not develop into anything deeper or more lasting.

Establishing Lasting Relationships

Out of all the people you meet, how do you choose those few who become your friends? Here, we shall consider factors relevant to both friendships and dating relationships; later, we shall specifically discuss dating and marriage.

Proximity and Familiarity

Proximity means *closeness*. (It comes from the same root as *approximate*.) Not surprisingly, *we are most likely to become friends with people who live or work in close proximity and who become familiar to us*. In one study, residents of a graduate housing project at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology were asked to list their three closest friends (Festinger, Schachter, & Back, 1950). The residents lived in two-story buildings with five apartments on each floor (Figure 14.8). On the average, they reported that about two-thirds of their closest friends lived in the same building, mostly on the same floor. People were most likely to make friends with their next-door neighbors.

At the start of a school year, Robert Hays (1985) asked college students to name two other students with whom they thought they might become friends. After 3 months, he found that more of the potential friends who lived close together had become friends than had those who lived farther apart.

Proximity increases the probability that two people will become friends or lovers, partly by giving them more opportunities to meet and talk and partly by just making them familiar with each other. Other things being equal, *the more often we come in contact with someone—or with an inanimate object such as a food or a painting—the more we tend to like that person or object* (Saegert, Swap, & Zajonc, 1973; Zajonc, 1968). This tendency is known as the **mere exposure effect**.

Similarity

Here's another finding that will hardly surprise you: Most close friends resemble one another in age, physical attractiveness, political and religious beliefs, intelligence, academic interests, religion, and attitudes (Laumann, 1969).

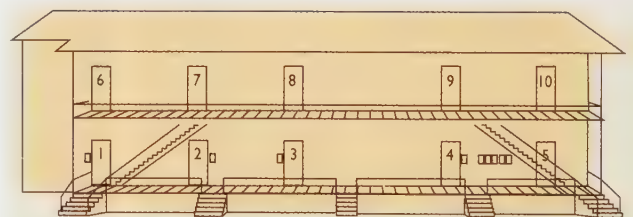
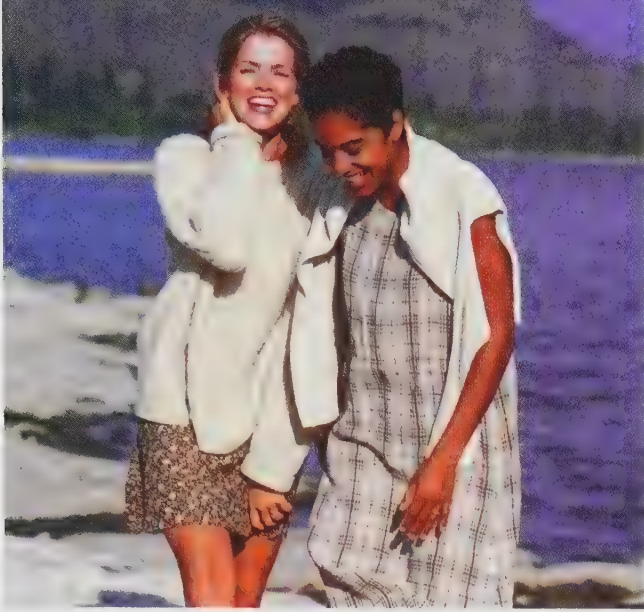


FIGURE 14.8 Students who lived in this graduate housing project generally chose friends who lived nearby. (From Festinger, Schachter, & Back, 1950.)



Even when friends differ in some ways, they generally have much in common, such as interests, attitudes, and level of education.

Most people also date and eventually marry people who closely resemble themselves in many ways. Couples who differ markedly in their education and interests may date for a while, but they are not likely to marry (Plomin, DeFries, & Roberts, 1977). Couples who marry in spite of major differences in personality are likely to have troubled marriages (Russell & Wells, 1991).

Do you like people better when you find out that their beliefs and attitudes are similar to yours? That question turns out to be a little trickier than it sounds at first. You probably like most of the people you meet, until you have a reason to alter your judgment. If you think at all about a new acquaintance's beliefs and attitudes, you probably assume that he or she shares your own beliefs and attitudes. . . because most people do, don't they? After all, your opinions and actions are normal and correct, so of course most other people share them (Alicke & Largo, 1995). Therefore, finding a disagreement with someone may *lower* your regard for them more than finding agreement with someone *increases* your regard (Rosenbaum, 1986).

Confirmation of Self-Concept

You might well be saying, "Big deal. People make friends with others who live nearby and resemble them. Psychologists needed research to demonstrate *that*?"

Sometimes, it is worthwhile to do research to demonstrate the obvious, just because what appears to be obvious is not always so. For example, suppose you are in a research study. First, you are asked to describe yourself. Then, two other people tell you how they reacted. After you have described yourself, the first person says, "I think you seem a pleasant, honest person. You're intelligent and you have some interesting ideas and a nice sense of humor."

The second says, "I hate to be rude, but frankly I think you seem rather superficial. You're trying to make a good

impression, but for me, you're failing. You drift aimlessly from one topic to another; you can't even organize your thoughts."

Which one would you choose as a partner? The obvious answer is the first one; indeed, just about everyone enjoys hearing some flattering comments. However, many people who have low self-esteem choose the person who gave them a low evaluation (Swann, 1997). Evidently, people believe and seek the company of someone who confirms their self-evaluation. Some who think little of themselves find it cognitively satisfying to be with others who share that low evaluation.

You can see the harmful consequences of this tendency. Someone with a low self-evaluation chooses friends and perhaps even a husband or wife who constantly criticizes. The result of all that criticizing is even lower self-esteem.

The Equity Principle

A friendship or romance works best if each partner believes that he or she is getting just about as good a deal as the other party is. The situation is not unlike a business relationship. According to **exchange or equity theories**, *social relationships are transactions in which partners exchange goods and services*. In some cases, the businesslike nature of the exchange is fairly blatant. In the "Singles' Ads" sections of many newspapers, those seeking a relationship describe what they have to offer ("35-year-old divorced male, 6'1", business executive, athletic. . .") and what they want in return ("seeks warm, caring, attractive woman, age 27–33 . . ."). The ads resemble the "asked" and "bid" columns for the stock exchange (Kenrick & Trost, 1989). People run ads for nonromantic friendships less often, but the same principle applies: A good friendship has a balance of giving and taking. Each partner gets enough reinforcement to support continued efforts.

As in business, a friendship or romantic relationship is most stable if both partners believe in the fairness of the deal. It is easiest to establish a stable relationship if the partners are about equally attractive and intelligent and contribute about equally to the finances and the chores, and so forth. With some couples, one partner is wealthier but the other is more attractive, or one is more intelligent but the other is very kind and considerate, or some other kind of compensation exists. Those arrangements can also seem fair, although it is more difficult to be sure.

CONCEPT CHECK

11. A person your own age from another country moves in next door to you. Neither of you speaks the other's language. Are you likely to become friends? What factors will tend to strengthen the likelihood of your becoming friends? What factors will tend to weaken it? (Check your answers on page 542.)

TRY IT
YOUR-
SELF

Special Concerns for Selecting a Mate

Choosing a partner for a marriage (or the equivalent of a marriage) is not the same as choosing other kinds of friends, mostly because of the extra dimension of raising children. Yes, I know, not everyone wants to get married, not all married couples plan to have children, and many unmarried people rear children. What I shall describe does not apply to everyone. Still, it applies to those who hope to marry and have children.

Physical Attractiveness

What characteristics do you look for in a person you date and perhaps eventually marry? If you are like most college students, you say that you want “someone who is intelligent, honest, easy to talk to, with a good sense of humor.”

Now imagine a friend says, “Hey, you’re not doing anything this weekend, right? How about going out on a blind date with my cousin who is visiting here for the weekend?”

“Well, I don’t know,” you reply. “Tell me about your cousin.”

“My cousin is intelligent, honest, easy to talk to, and has a good sense of humor.”

Are you eager to date this person? Probably not. Your friend did not even mention the cousin’s appearance, so you infer the worst. So, were you being dishonest when you said you wanted someone intelligent, honest, and easy to talk to? Not really. You did not mention appearance, because you assumed that people would take for granted your preference for good looks. (You also didn’t say that you hope your date speaks English; you don’t need to mention the obvious.)

In one study, social psychologists arranged blind dates for 332 freshman couples for a dance before the start of classes. They asked all the participants to fill out lengthy questionnaires, but the experimenters actually paired students at random. Midway through the dance, the experimenters separated the men and women and asked them to rate how much they liked their date and whether they hoped to date this person again. The only factor that influenced how much each liked the other was appearance (Walster, Aronson, Abrahams, & Rottman, 1966). Similarities of attitudes, personality, and intelligence counted for very little. We should not find this result surprising; after all, during a couple of hours at a dance, how much opportunity does a couple have to explore each other’s deepest beliefs and values? About all they knew about each other was related to appearance. Intelligence, honesty, and other character values do become important in a relationship, but not until later.

Physical attractiveness is influential not just for its own sake but also because it biases how we respond to what people say and do. As a rule, people regard their physically attractive acquaintances as highly sociable, dominant, sexually

responsive, mentally healthy, intelligent, and socially skilled (Feingold, 1992a). One group of experimenters asked subjects to rate the personality and intelligence of students in a series of yearbook photographs (Dion, Berscheid, & Walster, 1972). Participants rated the attractive students as more sensitive, kind, poised, and sociable than the others.

The Possible Biological Value of Attractiveness

Why is physical appearance so important to us? We take it so much for granted that we don’t even understand why there is a question. But think about other species: In many bird species, the male is more brightly colored than the female. Early in the mating season, brightly colored males sing vigorously from perches exposed at the treetops. Females shop around among the unmated males of their species and generally choose the one that is brightest in color and sings most often and most vigorously. In a few species, a female also prefers a male with an especially long tail (Figure 14.9). From an evolutionary standpoint, isn’t she making a foolish choice? The male she chooses has devoted a lot of his energies to feather color. (It takes much more energy to produce bright colors than dull ones.) Singing loudly from the treetop is practically an invitation to hawks and other predators. If he has a long tail, it may look pretty, but it interferes with his flying. Why should the female prefer a mate who wastes his energies and endangers his life?

Biologists eventually discovered that wasting energy and risking life was precisely the point (Zahavi & Zahavi, 1997). Only a healthy, vigorous male can afford to spend that much energy on colorful feathers or a long tail, or to risk predation by singing from an exposed perch. A weak or sickly male who spent his energies on “false advertising” would probably die. In effect, a colorful, singing male is screaming, “Look at me! I am so vigorous that I can afford to take crazy risks, and I have so much energy to spare that I can afford to waste it. You will certainly want me to be the father of your children!” The female, we presume, does not understand why she is attracted to colorful, loudly singing males. She just is, because throughout her evolutionary history, females who chose colorful, loudly singing males

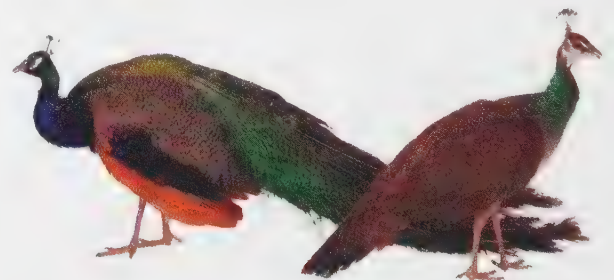


FIGURE 14.9 In a few bird species, males with very long tails attract more mates. However, they pay a price: The long tail impairs their flying abilities. As a rule, only very healthy and vigorous males have extra long tails.

generally had energetic partners who provided them with plenty of food while they were sitting on the nest and probably also provided good genes to the babies.

Now, back to humans: Is attractiveness in humans also a valid indicator of health, fertility, and other favorable characteristics? Theoretically, it should be. Certainly, many illnesses decrease people's attractiveness. Also, *good-looking* is in many regards similar to *normal*. A computer can take photographs of a large number of moderately similar people, all sitting in the same position and looking in the same direction, and average their faces. Most people regard the resulting averaged face as more attractive than most of the original faces (Langlois & Roggman, 1990; Langlois, Roggman, & Musselman, 1994). (See Figure 14.10.) In other words, a highly attractive face has an average nose, about an average mouth, about an average distance between the eyes, and so forth. If we note anything "unusual" about an attractive face, it is the absence of irregularities—no crooked teeth, no skin blemishes, no asymmetries or peculiarities.

Why is normal attractive? The hypothesis is that a normal face is probably a healthy face. The genes for an average face have spread in the population, presumably because they are linked to success. Any face that departs much from the average could show signs of disease or genetic mutation. So it would seem, at least. However, in one study, researchers obtained photos of hundreds of teenagers from long ago. Then, they asked people to examine the photos and rate the faces for attractiveness; they also obtained extensive medical records for the people in the photos. The ratings of attractiveness did not correlate reliably with health, either for adolescence or later life. People who were

rated attractive were more likely to marry, and especially to marry early, but unattractive people who did marry were just as likely to have children as the more attractive people (Kalick, Zebrowitz, Langlois, & Johnson, 1998). Evidently, at least for this one sample, attractiveness was false advertising; it had nothing to do with health or fertility.

If facial attractiveness is a poor cue to health, what about the rest of the body? According to one theory, men prefer women with a narrow waist and wide hips—a hip-to-waist ratio of about 0.7—because women with that ratio are most likely to be fertile. However, in one study, both men and women examined line drawings of women's figures, as in Figure 14.11, and selected which ones were most attractive and most likely to bear children successfully. Contrary to this theory, neither men nor women showed any consistent preference for a .7 waist-to-hip ratio. Most rated one of the thinner women as most attractive and one of the heavier women as most likely to bear children (Tassinary & Hansen, 1998). In short, the women who people generally regard as most attractive are neither the ones that scientists estimate to be most fertile (.7 ratio) nor the ones that most nonscientists estimate to be most fertile (more than .7 ratio). Attractiveness is generally honest advertising about a bird's health and vigor, but in humans, the evidence so far suggests that attractiveness is frequently false advertising.

SOMETHING TO THINK ABOUT

The studies just described were conducted in the United States. Would you expect attractiveness to be better correlated with health and vigor in any other societies? ★

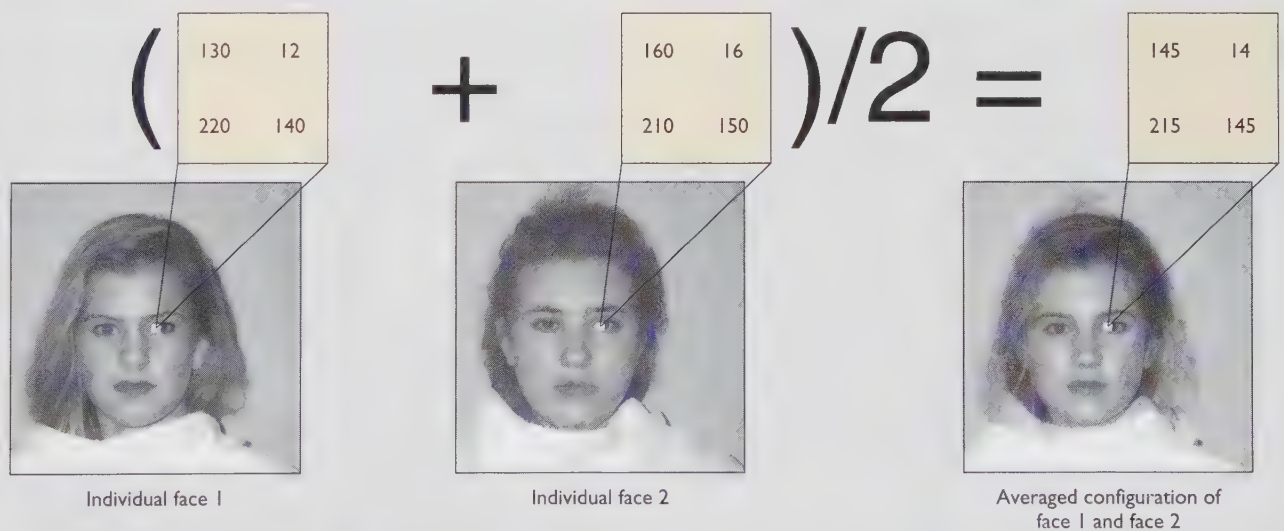


FIGURE 14.10 A computer averaged a set of faces by measuring the gray value of each point on each picture and then producing a new picture with the average of the grays at each point. This set of photos illustrates the procedure for two original faces. The numbers are for illustrative purposes only. Especially when a large number of faces have been averaged, most people rate the resulting "average" face more attractive than most of the originals. (From Langlois, Roggman, & Musselman, 1994).

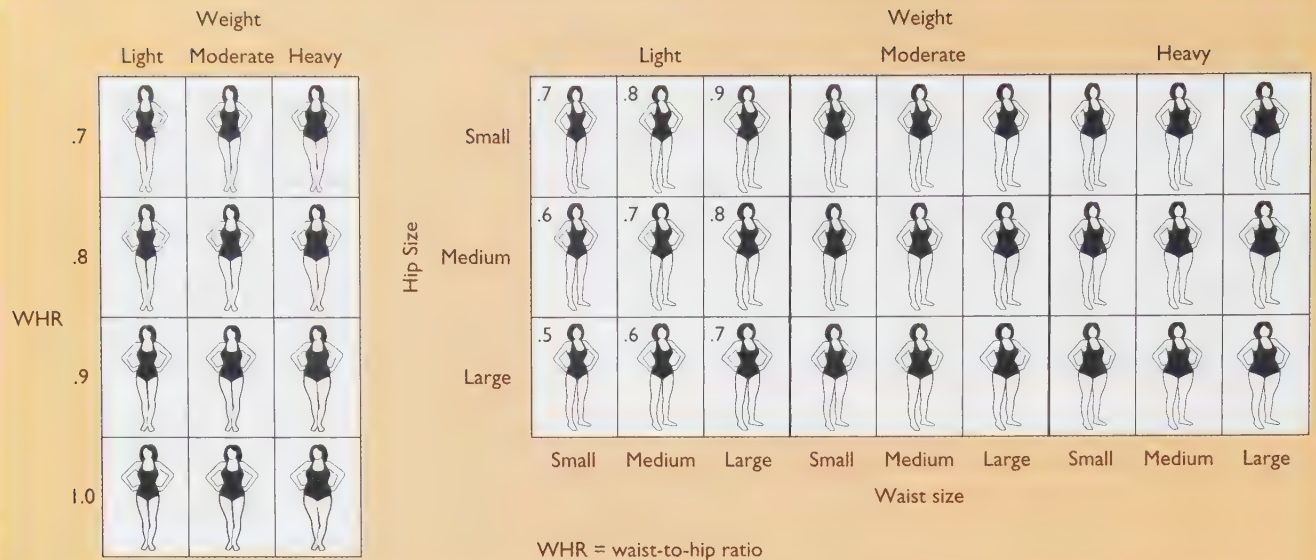


FIGURE 14.11 Which of these female figures do you regard as most attractive? Which do you think would be most likely to have babies successfully? In one study, most men and women picked one of the thinner women as most attractive but one of the heavier women as most likely to be fertile, thereby failing to support the theory that attractive means fertile. (From Tassinary & Hansen, 1998).

Men's Preferences and Women's Preferences

With most couples, who is older, the man or the woman? Who is more concerned about the other partner's appearance, the man or the woman? And who is more concerned about the partner's ability to earn a living and provide resources, the man or the woman?

You probably answered "the man" to the first and second questions and "the woman" to the third. The answers are the same in every known human society, although the degree of preference varies (Feingold, 1992b; Kenrick, 1994). (For example, in societies where a man must work for many years before he achieves economic success, young women prefer much older men. Where men can achieve success more quickly, women prefer men closer to their own age.)

Can we explain why men prefer younger women? Recall from Chapter 3 the *sociobiological approach*, also known as *evolutionary psychology*, which emphasizes the idea that social behavior is a product of evolutionary pressures (Buss, 1994; Kenrick, 1994). According to this approach, men prefer young women because women reach menopause and therefore stop being fertile at about age 40–50. Men have therefore evolved a tendency to find younger (probably fertile) women more attractive than older women. This theory sounds rather persuasive, although it is difficult to test. And, as we just saw, the evidence so far has not supported other speculations about a link between attractiveness and fertility.

Consider another difference between men and women: In every known culture, extramarital affairs by husbands are

generally more tolerated than those by wives. The degree of that difference varies; for example, the Swedes tolerate a woman's extramarital affairs more than the Chinese or Arabs do (Buss, 1994). In no culture, however, are affairs by wives considered more acceptable than those by husbands. From a sociobiological standpoint, one explanation is that a man cannot be sure he is the father of his wife's baby unless he knows that she has had sex with him alone. Consequently, a wife's infidelity is a threat; it means that he might unknowingly spend his life rearing another man's children. A woman does not have that problem; she knows that any child she bears must be her own. For her, a greater concern is that her husband might leave her to devote his attention to another woman. Surveys in several cultures find that men are more distressed than women by a partner's sexual affair with someone else; women tend to be more jealous when a partner becomes emotionally close to another woman (Buss, Larsen, Westen, & Semmelroth, 1992; Buunk, Angleitner, Oubaid, & Buss, 1996).

CONCEPT CHECK

- Suppose astronauts discover humanlike beings on another planet, whose biology and culture resemble ours except that all men have exactly the same wealth, and women remain fertile all their lives instead of losing their fertility at menopause. What would you predict about the mate preferences of men and women on this planet? (Check your answer on page 542.)

Romantic and Passionate Love

A couple that decides to marry announces to each other and to the world that they love each other more than anyone else and that they pledge to stay together as long as they both shall live. And yet a distressing percentage of marriages end in divorce. What went wrong?

Sometimes people change in ways they could not have foreseen, but in many cases the problem is that people simply marry the wrong partners. The Western custom of dating is well adapted for determining whether two people enjoy the same kinds of entertainment but not for determining the factors that are critical for long-term family life. Questionnaire studies have found that, as couples continue to date, their estimates of each other's sexual histories, activity preferences, and so forth become more *confident*, but not more *accurate* (Swann & Gill, 1997). Answer the questions below, first for yourself and second *as you think your dating partner would answer them*. (Several of these questions assume a heterosexual relationship; please disregard any items that do not apply to you.)

TRY IT YOURSELF

1. After you marry or establish another long-term relationship, how often would you want to visit your parents? your in-laws?
2. How many children do you want to have? how soon?

3. How do you want to raise your children? Should one partner stay home with the children full-time while they are young? Or should both partners share the responsibility for child care? Or should the children be placed in a day-care center?
4. Suppose one of you is offered a good job in one city and the other is offered a good job in a city a hundred miles away. Neither of you can find a satisfactory job in the other's city. How would you decide where to live?
5. Suppose a sudden financial crisis strikes. Where would you cut expenses to balance the budget? clothes? food? housing? entertainment?
6. How often do you plan to attend religious services?
7. How and where do you like to spend your vacations?
8. How often would you expect to spend an evening with friends, apart from your partner?

Were you uncertain about how your dating partner would answer any of these questions? If so, you are in the majority. And yet, disagreements about such questions are among the most common reasons for conflict in marriage or other long-term relationships. I am not suggesting that you should ask every person you date to fill out this questionnaire. However, before you get far enough into a relationship that love and marriage become a realistic possibility, you should discuss anything that is important to you. If you care about having children, find out what your partner thinks. If you want your eventual husband or wife to share your religious beliefs (or lack of them), discuss religion and your deepest values.



In a mature, lasting relationship, a couple can count on each other for care and affection through both the good times and the bad times.

Romantic Relationships that Last

When you hear about the high percentage of marriages that end in divorce, it is easy to despair, but many marriages still remain strong for a lifetime. Most characteristics of successful marriages are what you would probably expect (Karney & Bradbury, 1995):

- The husband and wife have similar attitudes and personalities.
- Both find sexual satisfaction in the relationship.
- The couple has a steady and adequate income.
- The husband has a good enough job to maintain self-respect.
- The wife was not pregnant before they married.
- The couple's parents also had successful marriages.

A successful marriage changes over the years, just as individual lives do. At first, the couple has the intense excitement of learning about each other and doing new things together. Years later, the two have worked out a complex system of shared work and understandings. Although they do not arouse each other's emotions as intensely or as frequently as before (Berscheid, 1983), they still love each other, perhaps even more deeply. If one of them becomes ill or dies, the emotion inherent in the mature relationship becomes vividly apparent.

THE MESSAGE *People Need Other People*

Few people enjoy living as a hermit, isolated from others. In prisons, one of the harshest forms of punishment is solitary confinement. Almost any social contact is better than none at all. However, many people may choose their friends and their spouse poorly. This module began with the observation that former Senator Proxmire thought people did not want or need to learn about research on the topic of love. Let's end with the observation that people definitely need to know more about love.

S U M M A R Y

- ★ *People's need for one another.* People crave the companionship of other people, especially others to whom they have felt emotionally close for a long time. This need can be regarded as part of human nature. (page 535)
- ★ *Short-term affiliation.* People in distress gain strength from associating even briefly with other people, especially others who have undergone or who expect to undergo similar distressing experiences. (page 536)
- ★ *More lasting relationships.* People generally choose friends and romantic partners who live near them, resemble them, and confirm their self-esteem. Relationships are most likely to survive and grow if each person believes that he or

she is getting about as good a deal as the other person is. (page 536)

★ *Marriage and similar attachments.* People have special considerations when choosing a potential marriage partner, because marriage usually implies a commitment to rearing children together. The behavior and interests of men are somewhat different from those of women. (page 538)

★ *Physical attractiveness.* In many nonhuman species, physical attractiveness is a reliable cue to the individual's health, vigor, and therefore desirability as a mate. In humans, attractiveness is a powerful determinant of mate choice but has not been demonstrably linked to health or other biologically useful functions. (page 538)

★ *Long-term romantic relationships.* Marriage and similar relationships often break up because the partners had chosen each other for the wrong reasons, without learning about the values and attitudes that are important for daily life and rearing a family. Marriages are successful when the partners have much in common and find ways to satisfy each other's needs. (page 541)

Suggestions for Further Reading

Berscheid, E. (1994). Interpersonal relationships. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 45, 79–129. Review of research about how people establish relationships and how those relationships change over time.

Buss, D. (1994). *The evolution of desire: Strategies of human mating*. New York: Basic Books. Discussion of the evolutionary influences on men's and women's preferences in a mate.

Terms

proximity (literally, "closeness") the tendency to choose as friends people with whom we come in frequent contact (page 536)

mere exposure effect the tendency to increase our liking for everything and everyone that has become familiar (page 536)

exchange or equity theories theories maintaining that social relationships are transactions in which partners exchange goods and services (page 537)

Answers to Concept Checks

11. Proximity and familiarity will strengthen the likelihood of your becoming friends. The similarity principle will weaken it. Because of the difference in languages, you will have little chance, at least at first, to discover any similarities in interests or attitudes. In fact, proximity will probably not be a potent force, because it serves largely as a means of enabling people to discover what they have in common. (page 537)
12. If all men are equally wealthy, women should have no reason to prefer older men and would presumably prefer men who are close to their own age. If women's fertility lasts as late in life as men's does, then the men on this

planet should not have a strong preference for younger women. (page 541)

Web Resources

Physical Attraction

miavx1.muohio.edu/~psybersite/attraction/

Four students in an advanced social psychology course developed this tutorial examining physical attraction and how it is affected by attributions and gender, and provide some cross-cultural comparisons and a quiz.

Dating, Love, Marriage, and Sex

www.cmhc.com/psyhelp/chap10/

The nature of attraction and love is one of the topics discussed in this chapter of the on-line book *Psychological Self-Help*.

Interpersonal Influence

Under what circumstances do we conform to the behavior of others?

Why do people act differently in groups than when they are alone?

In the spring of 1983, a strange epidemic swept through a Palestinian village in one of the territories occupied by Israel. The hospitals were flooded with people, mostly adolescents, complaining of headaches, dizzy spells, stomach pains, blurred vision, and labored breathing. The Palestinians accused the Israelis of poisoning the air or the water, perhaps in an effort to sterilize young Palestinian women. The Israelis replied with indignant denials.

Meanwhile, although physicians conducted extensive tests on all the patients, they could find nothing medically wrong with them. They studied the food, the air, the water, and every possible source of poison or contagious disease. They found no signs of anything that could cause illness. Finally, they concluded that all the symptoms were the result of anxiety, coupled with the power of suggestion (Paicheler, 1988). The Palestinians, understandably nervous about the political tensions in the region, *believed* they had been poisoned; this belief and the accompanying symptoms of illness spread from person to person just like a contagious disease.

We live in an ambiguous world. We often fail to understand what is happening or what we should do about it; when in doubt, we take our cues from what other people are doing. And following their lead is fine, if they happen to be better informed or wiser than we are.

Other people influence us in two major ways: First, they provide us with *information* (or misinformation). For example, if almost everyone else is flocking toward or away from something, they probably have a reason, so we should at least pay attention to whatever is driving their actions. Second, people set *norms*, defining what we are expected to do. In much of our social behavior, we follow rules of politeness, such as “do not interrupt,” “raise your hand if you want to speak in class,” and “wait in line after the people who arrived before you do.” People who persistently violate

these rules will anger other people and suffer the consequences. Here, we shall encounter many examples of both informational and normative influences.

Conformity

Conformity means *maintaining or changing one's behavior to match the behavior of others*. The pressure to conform sometimes exerts an overwhelming normative influence. Koversada, on the coast of the Adriatic Sea, is a small, totally nudist city (although people do sometimes dress for dinner at a formal restaurant). If a first-time visitor walks around the city wearing clothes, other people stop and stare, sometimes shaking their heads with disapproval. The visitor begins to feel awkward, out of place, and just as self-conscious as a naked person would be in a city of fully clothed people. Most visitors soon undress like everyone else (Newman, 1988).

Conformity can also serve informational functions, especially when we are not quite sure what we are seeing or hearing. One example is an illusion known as the **autokinetic effect**: *If you sit in a darkened room and stare at one small, stationary point of light, the point will eventually seem to move*. If someone says, “I see it moving in a zigzag manner” or “I see it moving slowly in a counterclockwise direction,” you are likely to perceive it the same way.



People tend to conform to the behavior of others, especially in ambiguous situations. Sometimes they will even conform when they doubt the wisdom of the other people's behaviors.

You will perceive some movement on your own, but other people's suggestions can greatly alter the apparent speed and direction of the movement.

Early research suggested that people are most likely to conform their opinions in ambiguous situations that make it difficult for people to be sure of their own judgment (Sherif, 1935). For example, there are no absolutely right or wrong styles of clothing; in matters such as politics, religion, or the movement of a single point of light in a darkened room, there may be a right answer, but we do not have enough information to be sure of that answer. Consequently, we rely on other people's opinions to help form our own.

Would we also conform to the opinions or behaviors of others if we were sure that we were right and they were wrong? To answer that question, Solomon Asch (1951, 1956) carried out a now-famous series of experiments.

Asch assembled groups of students and asked them to look at a vertical bar, as shown in Figure 14.12, which was defined as the model. He also showed them three other vertical bars (right half of Figure 14.12), and asked them which bar was the same length as the model. As you can see, the task is simple. Asch asked the students to give their answers aloud. He repeated the procedure with 18 sets of bars.

Only one student in each group was a real subject. All the others were confederates who had been instructed to give incorrect answers on 12 of the 18 trials. Asch arranged for the real subject to be the next-to-the-last person in the group to announce his answer so that he would hear most of the confederates' incorrect responses before giving his own (Figure 14.13). Would he go along with the crowd?

To Asch's surprise, 37 of the 50 subjects conformed to the majority at least once, and 14 of them conformed on more than half of the trials. When faced with a unanimous wrong answer by the other group members, the mean subject conformed on 4 of the 12 trials. Asch was disturbed by these results: "That we have found the tendency to conformity in our society so strong . . . is a matter of concern. It raises questions about our ways of education and about the values that guide our conduct" (Asch, 1955, p. 34).

Why did the subjects conform so readily? When they were interviewed after the experiment, some said they thought the rest of the group was correct or they guessed that an optical illusion was influencing the appearance of the bars. Others said they knew their "conforming" answers

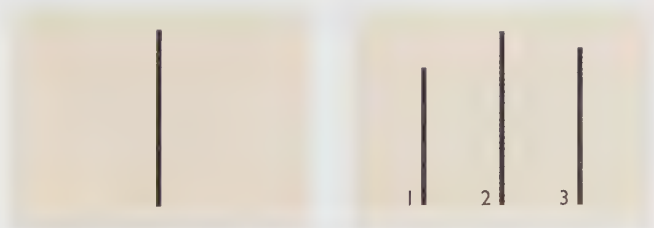


FIGURE 14.12 Choosing conformity: In Asch's conformity studies, subjects were asked to match one line with one of three other lines on another card. They were surrounded by people who gave obviously wrong answers.



FIGURE 14.13 Three of the eight subjects in one of Asch's experiments on conformity: The one in the middle is the real subject; the others are the experimenter's confederates. (From Asch, 1951.) In this test of the power of group pressure to induce conformity, people were asked to disagree with strangers for only a short time. The correct answers were clear—yet most subjects felt a strong pressure to conform to what the majority said.

were wrong but went along with the group for fear of being ridiculed. Reactions of the nonconforming subjects were interesting, too: Some were very nervous but felt dutybound to say how the bars looked to them. A few seemed socially withdrawn, as if they paid no attention to anyone else. Still others were supremely self-confident, as if to say, "I'm right and everyone else is wrong. It happens all the time."

Asch (1951, 1955) found that the amount of conforming influence depended on the size of the opposing majority. In a series of studies, he varied the number of confederates who gave incorrect answers from 1 to 15. He found that the subjects conformed to a group of 3 or 4 just as readily as they did to a larger group (Figure 14.14). However, the subjects conformed much less if they had an "ally." Being a minority of one is painful, but being in a minority of two is not as bad (Figure 14.15).

Over the years since Asch's experiments were conducted, similar studies have been conducted many times in

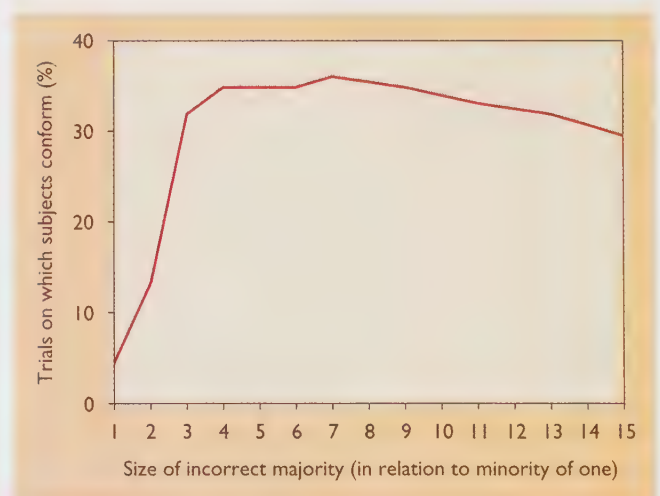


FIGURE 14.14 Asch (1955) found that conformity became more frequent as group size increased to about three, and then it leveled off.

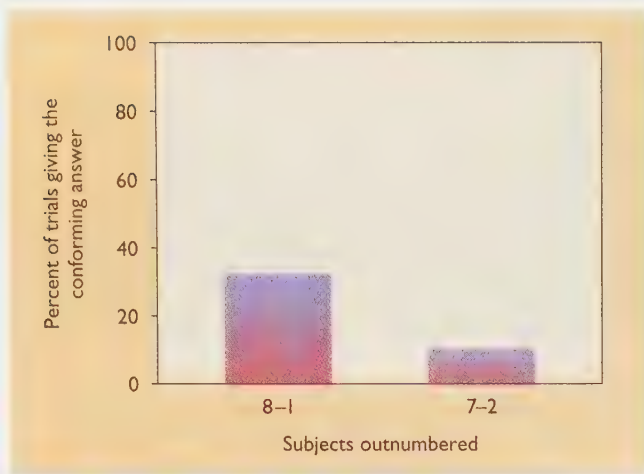


FIGURE 14.15 In Asch's experiments, subjects who were faced with a unanimous majority giving wrong answers conformed to the majority view on 32% of trials. Subjects who had one "ally" giving the correct answer were less likely to conform. Evidently, it is difficult to be in a minority of one, but less difficult to be in a minority of two.

many countries. In the United States, most studies show a slight decrease in the amount of conformity since the 1950s. In cultures that emphasize collectivist values, such as most Asian cultures, the percentage of conforming answers tends to be higher than in cultures that stress individualism. However, in those collectivist cultures, people seem to be motivated mostly by politeness, not wishing to embarrass the others by correcting their errors (Bond & Smith, 1996). That is, when researchers use what appears to be the "same" task in a different culture, they may not actually be testing the same psychological processes.

Accepting or Denying Responsibility Toward Others

Sometimes other people encourage us to do something we would not have done on our own, as in Asch's studies. Sometimes other people inhibit us from doing something that we would have done on our own. We look around to see what others are doing—or *not* doing—and we say, "Okay, I'll do that too. I'll do my fair share—no more, no less." Why do people sometimes work together to help one another and sometimes ignore the needs of others?

Bystander Helpfulness and Apathy

Suppose, while you are waiting at a bus stop, you see me trip and fall down, just 10 meters away from you. I am not screaming in agony but I don't get up right away either, so you are not sure whether I need help. Do you think you would probably come over and offer your help? Or would you just stand there and ignore me? Before you answer, try imagining the situation two ways: First, you and I are the



People watch other people's responses to help decide what their own should be. When a group of sidewalk Santas—who had gathered in Manhattan to promote a back-rub business—came to the aid of an injured cyclist, a few Santas made the first move and then the others decided to follow suit.

only people in sight. Second, there are a lot of other people nearby, none of whom is rushing to my aid. Does the presence of those other people make any difference in your response? (Note that it doesn't change *my* predicament. I am in the same amount of pain, regardless of whether one person or many people ignore me.)

Late one night in March, 1964, Kitty Genovese was stabbed to death near her apartment in Queens, New York. For 30 minutes, 38 of her neighbors listened to her screams. A few stood at their windows watching. None of them came to her aid or called the police. Why?

Bibb Latané and John Darley (1969) proposed that one reason the neighbors failed to help was **diffusion of responsibility**: *We tend to feel less responsibility for helping when other people are around than when we know that no one else can help.* Latané and Darley suggested that no one helped Kitty Genovese because everyone knew that many other people *could* help her.

In an experiment designed to test this hypothesis, a young woman ushered either one or two students into a room and asked them to wait a few minutes for the start of a market research study (Latané & Darley, 1968, 1969). She then went into the next room, closing the door behind her. There, she played a tape recording that made it sound as though she had climbed onto a chair and had fallen off. For about 2 minutes, she could be heard crying and moaning, "Oh . . . my foot . . . I can't move it. Oh . . . my ankle. . . ." Of the subjects who were waiting alone, 70% went next door and offered to help. Of the subjects who were waiting with someone else, only 13% offered to help.

Diffusion of responsibility is one possible explanation. Each person thinks, "It's not my responsibility to help any more than it is the other person's. And if we get blamed for not helping, it's as much that person's fault as it is mine." A second possible explanation is that the presence of other

people who are also doing nothing provides information (or misinformation). At first the situation is ambiguous: “Do I need to act, or not?” When you see other people doing nothing, you assume they know something you don’t know, and thus that the situation requires no action. In fact, the others are just as uncertain as you are, and they are drawing conclusions from *your* inaction. Social psychologists use the term **pluralistic ignorance** to describe *a situation where people say nothing and each person falsely assumes that everyone else has a different, perhaps better informed opinion*. Notice that the presence of other people exerts both normative and informational influences: Their inactivity implies that doing nothing is acceptable (a norm) and that the situation is not an emergency (information).

Social Loafing

Sometimes your success and rewards depend entirely on your own efforts. For example, when you take a test in one of your college courses, you are required to work alone. In many other cases, however, you work with other people as part of a team. For example, if you work for a company that gives workers a share of the profits, your rewards depend on both your own productivity and that of the other workers. Do you work as hard when the rewards depend on the group’s productivity as you do when they depend on your own efforts alone?

In many cases, the answer is “no.” In one experiment, students were told to scream and clap and try to make as loud a noise as possible, like cheerleaders at a sports event. Sometimes each student screamed and clapped alone; sometimes students acted in groups of two to six; and sometimes they acted alone but *thought* that other people

were screaming and clapping too. (They wore headphones so that they could not hear anyone else.) As a rule, students who screamed and clapped alone made more noise than students who were (or thought they were) part of a group (Latané, Williams, & Harkins, 1979). Social psychologists call this phenomenon **social loafing**—*the tendency to “loaf” (or work less hard) when sharing work with other people*. Social loafing has been demonstrated with several other behaviors as well. For example, suppose you were asked to “name all the uses you can think of for a brick” (such as *crack nuts*, *anchor a boat*, or *use as a doorstep*) and write each one on a card. You would probably use many cards if you were working by yourself, but you would fill out fewer cards if you were tossing them into a pile along with other people’s suggestions, to be evaluated as a group (Harkins & Jackson, 1985).

At this point you may be thinking, “Wait a minute. When I’m playing on a basketball team, I try as hard as I can. I don’t think I loaf just because others are working together.” And you are right; social loafing seldom occurs in team sports. (When it does, the fans boo.) The reason is that observers, including teammates, can easily see who is contributing and who is not. Even though the team wins or loses as a group, individual players also compete for recognition as individuals. People loaf in group projects only if they expect no reward for extra effort; they put out a serious effort if they expect other people to notice their effort, or if they think they can contribute something that other group members cannot (Shepperd, 1993; Williams & Karau, 1991).

Social loafing is a robust phenomenon, easy to demonstrate in many settings. Generally, the effect is large when people consider the task unimportant and smaller when they believe that much is at stake. (See Figure 14.16.) Other things being equal, men do more social loafing than women. (Perhaps women are more accustomed to working hard without getting credit.) Also, people in Western cultures do more social loafing than do people in Asian cultures, which stress the value of helping one’s group instead of just helping oneself (Karau & Williams, 1995). Japanese people will scorn anyone who does not do a fair share of a group effort. If some people continue to loaf, the ones who had been working generally quit. That is, in Japanese society, either everyone works or no one works (Shepperd, 1995).

CONCEPT CHECKS

13. Given what we have learned about social loafing, why are most people unlikely to work hard to clean up the environment?
14. Suppose the head of a large library wants the library staff to pay more attention to getting all the books into their correct locations. Currently, many of the books are misplaced, and the staff seem to be “loafing” at rearranging them. What could be done to encourage greater efforts? (Check your answers on page 550.)



In a tug-of-war or other task in which individuals pool their efforts, most people do not work as hard as they would when working alone. This is called “social loafing.” However, if participants know that each individual’s contribution will be measured separately, social loafing ceases and everyone puts out a full effort.

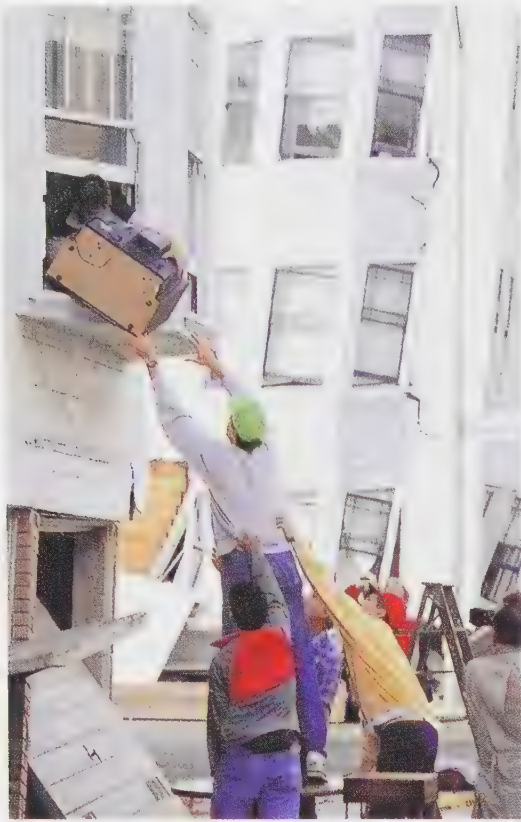


FIGURE 14.16 During a catastrophe, people abandon their usual tendencies toward bystander apathy and social loafing. Just after an earthquake in the San Francisco area, authorities ordered the residents in one area to evacuate their residences within 15 minutes. People who usually ignored one another immediately pitched in to help move their valuables.

Group Decision-Making

An organization that needs to make a decision will frequently set up a committee to look into the issues and make recommendations. We prefer a committee to an individual because the committee has more time, more total information, and fewer peculiarities and biases than any individual has. Nevertheless, a group is subject to the influences of conformity and social loafing, which sometimes interfere with reaching the best possible decisions.

Group Polarization

If nearly all the people who compose a group lean in the same direction on a particular issue, the group as a whole will tend to move even further in that direction after they discuss that issue. This phenomenon is known as **group polarization**. Note that, in this case, *polarization* does not mean that the group breaks up into fragments favoring different positions. Rather, it means that, after discussing the issues, the members of a group move *together* toward one pole (extreme position) or the other. For example, a group of

people who are opposed to abortion or in favor of animal rights or opposed to gun regulations will, after discussing the issue among themselves, generally become more extreme in their views than they had been at the start (Lamm & Myers, 1978).

Group polarization occurs because of both informational and normative influences (Isenberg, 1986). During the group discussion, the members become aware of new arguments and new information. If most of the members were leaning in one direction at the start, the group will hear many new arguments favoring that side of the issue and few or none for the opposition (Burnstein & Vinokur, 1973, 1977). The lack of balance between positive and negative arguments is essential for group polarization (Kuhn & Lao, 1996). Also, as the members of the group become aware of the consensus during the discussion, they feel pressure to conform. The pressure to conform is strongest for people who believe that they are not fully accepted by the rest of the group (Noel, Wann, & Branscombe, 1995). They can increase their acceptance by the group if they emphasize how vigorously they support its views and goals.

CONCEPT CHECK

- 15.** Is a jury more likely to reach a biased or extreme decision than a single individual would be? (Check your answer on page 550.)

Groupthink

One extreme form of group polarization is known as **groupthink**, when *the members of a group suppress their doubts about a group's poorly thought-out decision, for fear of making a bad impression or disrupting the harmony of the group* (Janis, 1972, 1985). In some cases, dominant members of the group actually ask dissenters to be quiet; more often, dissenters silence themselves. One dramatic example of groupthink led to the Bay of Pigs fiasco of 1962. President John F. Kennedy and his advisers were considering a plan to support a small-scale invasion of Cuba at the Bay of Pigs. They assumed that a small group of Cuban exiles could overwhelm the Cuban army and trigger a spontaneous rebellion of the Cuban people against Fidel Castro and his government. Most of the advisers who doubted this assumption felt pressured to keep quiet; one who did express his doubts was told that he should loyally support the president, who had already made up his mind. Within a few hours after the invasion began, all the invaders were either killed or captured. The decision-makers themselves wondered how they could have made such a stupid decision.

Another example of groupthink was NASA's ill-fated decision to launch the space shuttle *Challenger* on a cold morning in 1986. The top decision-makers let it be known that they had strong economic and public-relations reasons for launching the shuttle on schedule. Project engineers who



Many organizations try to resist the tendency toward groupthink—the tendency to stifle dissenting views and proceed to a possibly disastrous decision. During the Renaissance, European kings sometimes called on a “fool” (or court jester) to describe some proposal in a fresh and possibly amusing light. In a court composed largely of yes-men, the fool sometimes was the only one who could openly point out the folly of a proposed action without fear of reprisals.

knew the rocket booster was unsafe at low temperatures dutifully kept quiet and hoped for the best. Then, 73 seconds after the launch, the *Challenger* exploded because of an O-ring that was unable to function at low temperatures.

In both the Bay of Pigs incident and the *Challenger* disaster, group members who doubted the wisdom of the decision kept quiet and thus created an illusion of unanimous support. Originally, psychologists believed that groupthink occurs mostly in highly cohesive groups, such as fraternal or religious organizations, where the members think that it would be rude to criticize one another's views. Later research has found that almost all groups, not just cohesive ones, are capable of exerting pressure to conform (Aldag & Fuller, 1993).

Irving Janis (1985) suggests several techniques for reducing the likelihood of groupthink: Leaders should encourage dissent. The group can be divided into subgroups to see whether they arrive at the same conclusions in independent discussions. Leaders should consult their advisers one by one in private. The group should seek the advice of outside experts, including those with dissenting opinions. In any case, group members who entertain doubts about a leader's decision should remember the lessons of the Bay of Pigs and the *Challenger*: When much is at stake, it is better to risk angering one's leader than to go along with a possibly disastrous decision.

THE MESSAGE To Conform or Not to Conform?

Conforming to what others do is not, in itself, a bad idea. When I drive on the right side of the road, I am rather relieved that other people are being conformists and also driving on the right side. Problems arise when we are surrounded by people who are expressing an extreme and possibly wrong opinion (as in group polarization) or by people who are doing nothing when something needs to be done (as in bystander apathy). We need to be alert: to conform when conformity is helpful or at least harmless but to resist when conformity is dangerous.

S U M M A R Y

- ★ *Types of social influence.* People influence our behavior by providing information (right or wrong) and by setting norms that they enforce by providing or withholding their approval. (page 544)
- ★ *Conformity.* Many people conform to the majority view even when they are confident that the majority is wrong. An individual is as likely to conform to a group of three as to a larger group, but an individual who has an ally is less likely to conform to the majority. (page 544)
- ★ *Diffusion of responsibility.* People in groups are less likely than an isolated individual to come to the aid of another because they experience a diffusion of responsibility. (page 546)
- ★ *Social loafing.* People working together on a task tend to exert less effort than people who are working independently. However, people will work just as hard on the group task if they are evaluated on the basis of their individual performances or if they believe their contributions will make a big difference to the group's success. (page 547)
- ★ *Group polarization.* Groups of people who lean mostly in the same direction on a given issue often make decisions that are more extreme than the decisions that most individuals would have made on their own. (page 548)
- ★ *Groupthink.* Groupthink occurs when members of a cohesive group fail to express their opposition to a decision, for fear of making a bad impression or harming the cohesive spirit of the group. (page 548)

Suggestion for Further Reading

Cialdini, R. B. (1993). *Influence: Science and practice* (rev. ed.). New York: William Morrow. One of the most enjoyable and entertaining books in psychology. Buy a copy and take it with you on vacation.

Terms

conformity maintaining or changing one's behavior to match the behavior of others (page 544)

- autokinetic effect** the illusory perception that a point of light in a darkened room is in motion (page 544)
- diffusion of responsibility** the tendency to feel less responsibility for helping when other people are around than when we know that no one else can help (page 546)
- pluralistic ignorance** a situation where people say nothing and each person falsely assumes that everyone else has a different, perhaps better informed opinion. (page 547)
- social loafing** the tendency to “loaf” (or work less hard) when sharing work with other people (page 547)
- group polarization** the tendency of a group whose members lean in the same direction on a particular issue to become more extreme in its views after discussing the issue as a group (page 548)
- groupthink** a process by which the members of a group suppress their doubts about a group’s poorly thought-out decision, for fear of making a bad impression or disrupting the harmony of the group (page 548)

Answers to Concept Checks

13. For the task of protecting the environment, each person is part of a group containing billions of other people. Social loafing is likely because many one-person contributions, such as picking up litter, would not earn individual credit or recognition. Also, each person thinks, “What good could one person do with such a gigantic problem?” When people believe that their own contribution would not make a noticeable difference, they tend to engage in social loafing. (page 547)
14. One approach would be to make the contributions of each staff member more apparent (because social loafing is common when people do not see that their own efforts make much difference). For example, assign each person a different set of shelves and report which shelves have shown the greatest improvement in orderliness. A similar approach can be used for other examples of loafing on the job. (page 547)
15. Group polarization occurs when nearly all the members of a group lean in the same direction before they start discussing the issue. If a jury were almost unanimous, with one or two uncertain members, group polarization would probably move the group toward a unanimous verdict. However, a jury that starts out divided would be more likely to compromise than to move toward an extreme. Most research has found juries and similar groups to be no more extreme or biased than the average individual (Kerr, MacCoun, & Kramer, 1996). (page 548)

Web Resources

Groupthink

www.nwmissouri.edu/nwcourses/martin/socialpsych/groupthink/sld001.htm

Doug Martin of Northwest Missouri State University developed this slide presentation that summarizes Janis’s concept of Groupthink.

Groupthink: Theoretical Framework

choo.fis.utoronto.ca/FIS/Courses/LIS2149/Groupthink.html

This three-page series by Chun Wei Choo of The University of Toronto begins with an elaborate diagram showing the antecedent conditions and observable consequences of Groupthink; on pages 2 and 3 are steps to minimize its development.

The Power of the Social Situation

Why do people sometimes engage in self-defeating behavior?

How can we change the situation to minimize such behavior?

Back in the 1960s, several world problems seemed to threaten the very future of civilization. The Vietnam War seemed to go on forever; the nations of the world seemed to be preparing for global nuclear war; racial injustice and discrimination were widespread in the United States; we were beginning to recognize how badly people were damaging the environment. As a high-school and college student at the time, I had grandiose dreams that I was going to save the world. I wasn't sure how, but I thought psychological research was one possibility. I hoped to somehow change human nature so that people would stop being so cruel and selfish.

Now here we are, many years later, and I reflect on the people who really did make the world a better place. Some made their impact through moral leadership or politics—Martin Luther King, Jr., Mother Teresa, Alexander Solzhenitsyn, Nelson Mandela, and others. But there have also been many who improved the world through technology—a route that I never even contemplated during my youthful “save the world” fantasies. For example, the engineers who devised spy satellites made possible the international treaties banning tests of nuclear weapons. (Without the capacity to watch one another, competing countries would never have agreed to such treaties.) The engineers who developed computers, printers, and modems spread freedom of the press to every technologically advanced country. (Any country that allows people to have computers is giving them printing presses.) These technological advances changed human *behavior* without changing human *nature*.

The general point here is that much of our behavior is controlled by the situation—sometimes the technological situation, sometimes the social situation. A situation can pressure us, or virtually compel us, to behave either in constructive ways or else in uncooperative and self-

defeating ways. We need to recognize the power of these situations, so that we can avoid or change the most harmful ones.

Behavior Traps

What would you think of someone who knowingly paid a great deal more for something than it was worth? Or someone who confessed to a crime even though the police admitted they did not have enough evidence for a conviction? Or someone who used up all of his or her resources at once instead of saving some for later? You would probably question that person's intelligence or sanity. And yet, under certain circumstances, you might act the same way yourself. Sometimes, we fall into a **behavior trap**—*a situation that coerces us into self-defeating behaviors*. We call such situations “traps” because people wander into them without realizing the danger; once they see the danger, they cannot find their way out. We shall consider three examples: escalation of conflict, the prisoner's dilemma, and the commons dilemma.

Escalation of Conflict

Sometimes a conflict or competition between two sides progressively escalates: After one side increases its effort and investment, the other side increases and then surpasses the first side's effort, thus prompting the first side to retaliate, and so forth. Eventually, both sides have invested far more than the original dispute was worth, but neither wants to quit and admit defeat.



Social pressures drive people to expose themselves to many kinds of risk. It is easier to avoid these situations than to escape them after the danger is evident.

For example, imagine that you and I and a few other people are at an auction. The auctioneer explains that the next item up for bids is a dollar bill, which she will sell to the highest bidder, even if the highest bid is only a few cents. There is one catch, however; at the end, when someone finally buys the dollar bill, the second-highest bidder must pay his or her bid to the auctioneer also, receiving nothing in return. So, for example, if I bid 5 cents, you bid 10 cents, and the bidding stops there, you would buy the dollar bill for 10 cents and I would simply lose my 5 cents.

Suppose that we both think this sounds like a good deal and we plunge right in. I bid 5 cents, you bid 10, I bid 15, and the bidding continues. Eventually you bid 90 cents and I bid 95. Now, what do you do? If you let me have the dollar bill for 95 cents, you will lose 90 cents. So you bid one dollar, hoping at least to break even. What do I do? If I stop bidding, I lose 95 cents. But if I can buy the dollar for \$1.05, I sustain a net loss of only 5 cents. So I bid \$1.05. Then you bid \$1.10, because you would rather lose 10 cents than lose a whole dollar. And so on. After a while, we start to lose track of the economics and begin to get angry with each other. After all, as soon as one of us quits bidding, the other one will “win.”

Psychologists have repeatedly set up such situations to see what would happen. They have usually managed to sell their dollar bills for prices over \$1, usually in the range of \$3 to \$5, and once for \$25 (Brockner & Rubin, 1985). As soon as the bidding went over \$1, bidders became increasingly distressed—sweating, trembling, sometimes even crying. Many of them offered excuses for themselves, such as “I’m sorry I behaved so irrationally, but I had a couple of beers before I came over here.” (At the end of the experiment, the psychologists always returned the money that the bidders paid them, although they had not promised to do so.)

The point of this study is *not*: “Here’s a good scam you can use to work your way through college.” The point is that, once a person gets into a situation like this, it is hard to get out. And similar situations do arise in real life. The arms race between the United States and the Soviet Union was a classic example: From the end of World War II until 1991 (when the Soviet Union collapsed), the two countries devoted enormous sums of money to building weapons. Periodically, critics would ask, “Does it really make sense to spend this much money on weapons?” And the reply was, “We have already spent an enormous amount. Having spent so much already, we may as well spend a little more to be sure that we have more weapons than the other side.”

Similar situations occur in everyday life (Staw & Ross, 1989). Someone who has lost money by gambling may continue gambling to avoid admitting that the original gamble was a mistake. Someone who has invested in a stock that lost money may hold onto the stock (and perhaps continue losing money) rather than sell it and accept the loss. A company that has invested millions on developing a new, unsuccessful product may invest additional millions to finish the product. Labor negotiations may persist fruitlessly

because both sides need a “victory” to justify the strike they have already endured. Perhaps you can think of additional examples.

Cooperation and Competition in the Prisoner’s Dilemma

In some situations, you have a choice between two actions—an action that seems best for you and one that seems best for your group. However, if everyone in the group chooses the action that seems best for himself or herself, everyone will suffer. The problem is not simply human selfishness; the problem is inherent in the situation itself.

For example, consider the **prisoner’s dilemma**, a *situation where people must choose between a cooperative act and an act that could benefit only themselves while hurting others*. There are many versions of this dilemma, but let’s start with the original: You and a partner are arrested and charged with armed robbery. The police take each of you into separate rooms and ask you to confess. If neither of you confesses, the police will not have enough evidence to convict you of armed robbery, but they can convict you of a lesser offense that carries a sentence of 1 year in prison. If either of you confesses and testifies against the other, the confessor will go free and the other will get 20 years in prison. If you both confess, you will each get 5 years in prison. Each of you knows that the other person has the same options. Figure 14.17 illustrates your choices.

If your partner does not confess, it is to your own advantage to confess, because you will go free. (Your partner

	Partner confesses	Partner doesn't confess
You confess	5 years (you) 5 years (partner)	0 years (you) 20 years (partner)
You don't confess	20 years (you) 0 years (partner)	1 year (you) 1 year (partner)

FIGURE 14.17 In the prisoner’s dilemma, each person considering the choice alone finds it beneficial to confess. But when both people confess, they suffer worse consequences than if both had refused to confess.

will get 20 years in prison, but let's assume you are mostly interested in yourself.) If your partner does confess, it is still to your advantage to confess—you get only 5 years in prison instead of 20. So, you confess. Your partner, reasoning the same way, also confesses, so you both get 5 years in prison. If you had both kept quiet, you would each have served only 1 year in prison. The situation led you both to uncooperative, self-defeating behavior.

If you and your partner could have discussed your strategy, you would have agreed not to confess. Then, when the police took you to separate rooms, you would each hope that the other would keep the bargain. And if your friend did keep the bargain, what should you do? Confess, of course! We're back where we started.

The two of you are likely to cooperate only if you can stay in constant communication with each other (Nemeth, 1972). If each can listen to everything the other one says, you know that, if one confesses, the other will retaliate immediately. Indeed, as a general principle, self-defeating behaviors often arise because of lack of communication. Marriages fail, labor unions start costly strikes, and countries go to war because the two sides do not communicate enough about what each side is willing to do and willing to accept in return (Thompson & Hrebec, 1996).

The prisoner's dilemma can also be stated in terms of gains instead of losses. Social psychologists have invented games where each player chooses between two moves, one cooperative and the other competitive. The moves the players make determine their costs and rewards (Figure 14.18). To complicate matters (and make them more interesting), the game continues through many rounds. If one player

chooses the competitive response for one trial, the other player can retaliate on the next. Players earn the most rewards if both choose the cooperative move. Frequently, however, one player chooses the competitive response, the other retaliates, and both players lose rewards (Axelrod & Dion, 1988).

In the long run, which is the better strategy in life? The prisoner's dilemma is much like a business deal: One person promises to mail a product and the other person promises to mail a check, and then both have to choose whether to cooperate (send the promised product or check) or compete (send nothing and hope to get something in return). If you dealt with a different person each time, you would gain more by competitive moves than by cooperative moves. But real life isn't like that. People who like to cooperate find other people who cooperate, and they do business among themselves. The uncooperative people who are always trying to cheat their opponents have more and more difficulty getting anyone to do business with them (Wilson, Near, & Miller, 1996).

CONCEPT CHECK

- 16.** Suppose you are playing the prisoner's dilemma game shown in Figure 14.18. Both you and the other player know that you will play for exactly ten times. Also, suppose that you are interested only in the economic outcome, not in the morality of your decision, and that you do not expect to meet the other player ever again. In this situation, many people would make the cooperative choice on the first nine rounds of the game and the competitive move on the final round. Why? (Check your answer on page 557.)

		PLAYER 2	
		Competes	Cooperates
PLAYER 1	Competes	Lose 50¢ / Lose 50¢	Lose \$1 / Win \$1
	Cooperates	Lose \$1 / Win \$1	Win 50¢ / Win 50¢

FIGURE 14.18 In this game based on the prisoner's dilemma, each player can choose either the cooperative move or the competitive move. If both cooperate, each wins 50 cents; in other choices, one or both players lose money.

The Commons Dilemma

Here is another case where people hurt themselves and others by considering only their own short-term interests (Hardin, 1968): In the **commons dilemma**, *people who share a common resource tend to overuse it and therefore make it unavailable in the long run*. The commons dilemma takes its name from this parable: You are a shepherd in a small village with a piece of land, called the commons, that everyone is free to share. Most of the time, your sheep graze on your own land, but when a few of them need a little extra grass, you are free to take them to the commons. There are 50 shepherds in the village, and the commons can support about 50 sheep a day. So, if each shepherd takes an average of one sheep per day to the commons, everything works out fine. But suppose a few shepherds decide to take several sheep per day to the commons to save the grass on their own land. Not to be outdone, other shepherds do the same. Soon the commons is barren and useless to all.

Social psychologists have simulated the commons dilemma, like the prisoner's dilemma, in laboratory games. In one study, college students were asked to sit around a

bowl that contained 10 nuts (Edney, 1979). They were told that they could take as many nuts as they wanted any time they chose. Every 10 seconds, the number of nuts remaining in the bowl would be doubled. The object of the game was to collect as many nuts as possible. Clearly, the rational strategy is to let the nuts double every 10 seconds for a while and then to “harvest” some to divide among the participants. But most of the groups never made it past the first 10 seconds. The subjects simply plunged in and grabbed as many nuts as they could, immediately exhausting the resources.

Some people do cooperate, however. Consider this scenario: Imagine you are in the fishing business. The numbers of fish have been declining, and the government has asked you and all the other fishing companies to reduce your annual catch. However, you know the government cannot enforce this regulation, so you can still catch more than your assigned share without penalty. What do you do? About half of college students who were asked this question said they would cooperate and limit their catch (Baron, 1997). If they were actually depending on fishing to make a living, they might decide differently (Figure 14.19). Still, the reasons they gave were interesting. Students said that they wanted to do their part to make the world a better place and that they thought, by cooperating, they would influence others to cooperate too, and thus benefit themselves in the long run.

Obedience to Authority

One final example of a self-defeating situation arises when people obey an authority who gives bad orders. Ordinarily, if someone you hardly know orders you to do something unpleasant, saying “you *have* to do this,” you would probably refuse quite vehemently. Sometimes, however, you may get into a situation where you feel obligated to obey unreasonable orders. We might have thought that only people with a rigid, authority-worshipping personality would follow objectionable orders, but evidence has shown that some situations build up such powerful pressures that almost anyone obeys.

Research on this topic was inspired by reports of atrocities in the Nazi concentration camps during World War II. Those who had committed the atrocities defended themselves by saying that they were only obeying orders. International courts rejected that defense, and outraged people throughout the world told themselves, “If I had been there, I would have refused to follow such orders” and “It couldn’t happen here.”

What do you think? Could it happen here? Stanley Milgram (1974) set up an experiment to discover whether a carefully designed situation could trap people into obeying apparently dangerous orders. Milgram’s experiment quickly became one of the most famous studies in psychology, with major ethical and scientific implications.

Hypothesis When an authority figure gives normal people instructions to do something that might hurt another person, at least some of them will obey, under carefully designed circumstances.

Method Two adult male subjects arrived at the experimental room—the real subject and a confederate of the experimenter pretending to be a subject. (They were not college students. The experimenters wanted results that would generalize to a broad population. They also wanted to minimize the risk that the subjects would guess the true purpose of the experiment.) The experimenter told the subjects that this was an experiment on learning and that one subject would be the “teacher” and the other the “learner.” The teacher would read lists of words through a microphone to the learner, who would sit in a nearby room. The teacher would then test the learner’s memory for the words. Every time the learner made a mistake, the teacher was to deliver an electric shock as punishment.

The experiment was rigged so that the real subject was always the teacher and the confederate was always the learner. The teacher watched as the learner was strapped into the shock device, so he or she knew that the learner could not escape (Figure 14.20). The learner never actually received any shocks, but the teacher was led to believe that he did. In fact, before the start of the study, the experimenter also had the teacher feel a “sample shock” from the machine, demonstrating that the machine really worked.

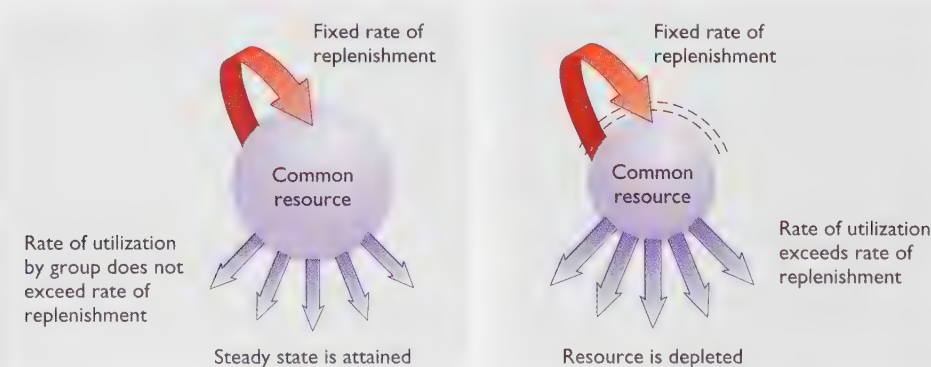


FIGURE 14.19 The commons dilemma: Unless the users agree to moderate their use of a common resource, it will soon be used up. For example, years of overfishing off the coast of Newfoundland so thoroughly depleted the fish population that the Canadian government finally had to ban commercial fishing.



FIGURE 14.20 In Milgram's experiment, a rigged drawing selected a confederate of the experimenter to be the "learner." Here, the learner is strapped to a device that is supposedly designed to deliver shocks.

The experiment began uneventfully. The teacher read the words and tested the learner's memory for them. The learner made many mistakes. The teacher sat at a shock generator that had levers to deliver shocks ranging from 15 volts up to 450 volts, in 15-volt increments (Figure 14.21). The experimenter instructed the teacher to deliver a shock every time the learner made a mistake, beginning with the 15-volt switch and raising the voltage by 15 volts for each successive mistake. As the voltage went up, the learner in the next room cried out in pain and even kicked the wall.

In one version of the experiment, the learner complained that he had a heart condition. If a teacher asked who would take responsibility for any harm done to the learner, the experimenter replied that he (the experimenter) would take responsibility but insisted that "while the shocks may be painful, they are not dangerous." When the shocks reached 150 volts, the learner called out in pain and begged to be let out of the experiment, complaining that his heart was bothering him. Beginning at 270 volts, he responded to shocks with agonized screams. At 300 volts, he shouted that he would no longer answer any questions. After 330 volts, he

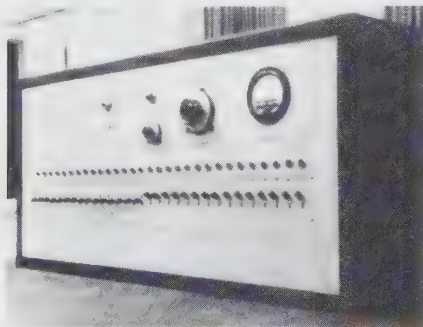


FIGURE 14.21 The "teacher" in Milgram's experiment flipped switches on this box, apparently delivering stronger and stronger shocks for each successive error that the "learner" made. The situation was designed to appear realistic, although the device did not actually shock the learner.

made no response at all. Still, the experimenter ordered the teacher to continue asking questions and delivering shocks. (Remember, the learner was not really being shocked. The screams of pain were being played from a tape recorder.)

Results Of 40 subjects, 25 continued to deliver shocks all the way up to 450 volts. The people who did so were not sadists. They were normal adults, recruited from the community through newspaper ads. They were paid a few dollars for their services, and those who asked were told that they could keep the money even if they quit. (Not many asked.) People from all walks of life obeyed the experimenter's orders, including blue-collar workers, white-collar workers, and professionals. Most of them grew quite upset and agitated while they were supposedly delivering shocks to the screaming learner, but they kept right on.

Interpretation The level of obedience Milgram observed depended on certain factors that he injected into the situation. One was that the experimenter agreed to take responsibility. (Remember the diffusion of responsibility principle.) Another factor was that the experimenter started with a small request, asking the subject to press the lever for a 15-volt shock, and then gradually progressed to stronger shocks. (Remember the foot-in-the-door principle; remember also Skinner's shaping principle.)

We can identify many other contributing factors, and we can imagine many ways to change the procedure that would probably also change the results. Figure 14.22 and Figure 14.23 illustrate the results of a few variations in procedure that Milgram tried. For example, subjects were more obedient to an experimenter who remained in the same room than to one who left. They were less obedient if they needed to force the learner's hand back onto the shock plate. If additional "teachers" divided the task—the other "teachers" also being confederates of the experimenter—a participant was very likely to obey if the others obeyed, but unlikely to obey if the others disobeyed.



FIGURE 14.22 In one variation of Milgram's standard procedure, he asked the teacher to hold the learner's hand on the shock electrode. This close contact with the learner decreased obedience to less than half of its usual level; still, some teachers continued following orders to deliver shocks. (From Milgram's 1965 film, *Obedience*.)

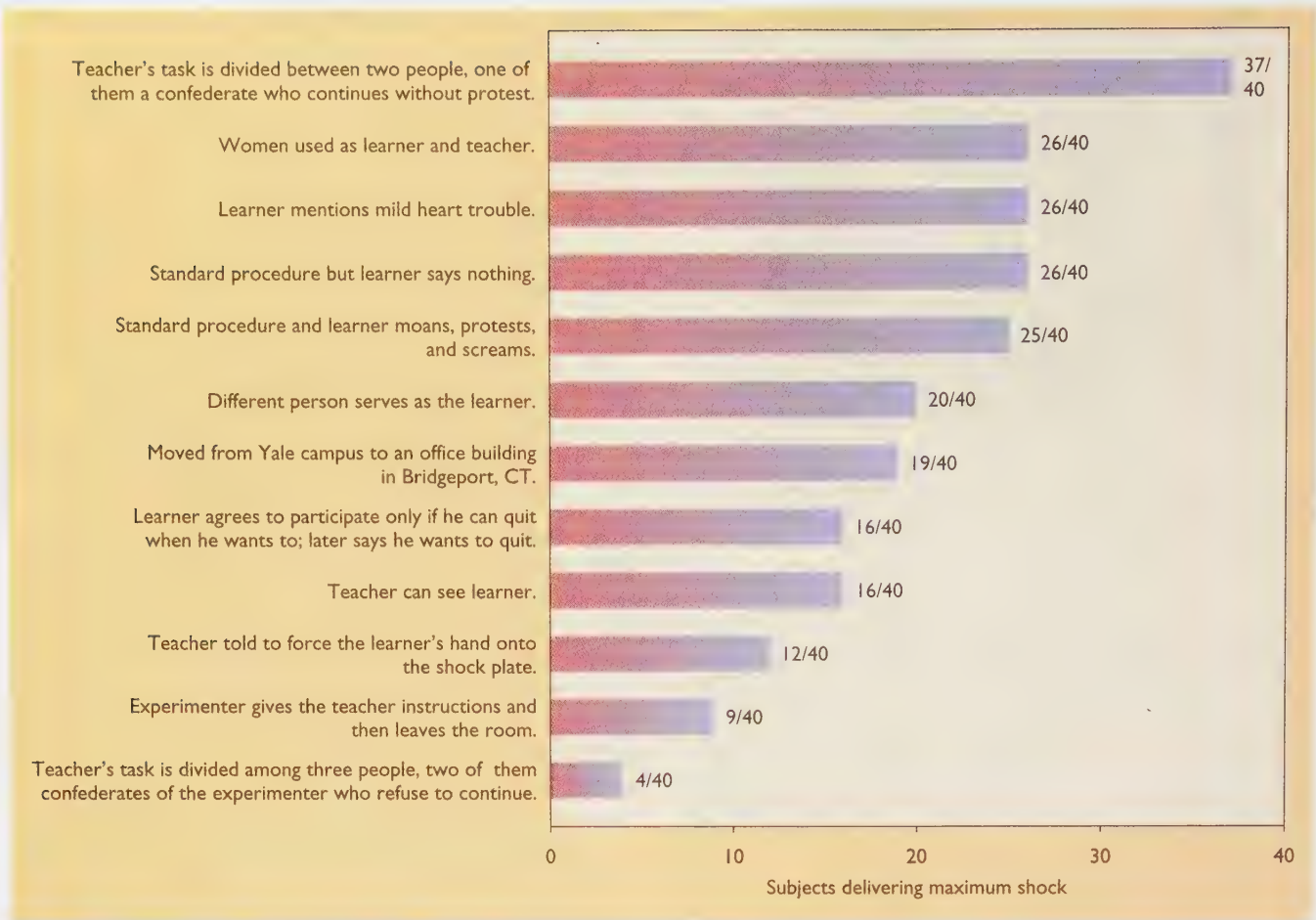


FIGURE 14.23 Milgram varied his procedure in many ways to find out what elements promoted or inhibited obedience. Division of responsibility increased obedience; an implication of personal responsibility decreased obedience. Under all conditions, some people obeyed and others did not.

Still, the remarkable conclusion remains that, under a variety of conditions, many normal people followed orders from an experimenter they had just met, even though they thought they might hurt or even kill someone. Imagine how much stronger the pressure to obey orders from a government or military leader would be.

Ethical Issues Milgram's experiment told us something about ourselves that we did not want to hear. No longer could we say, "Something like what happened in the Nazi concentration camps could never happen here." We found that most of us tend to follow orders, even quite offensive orders. We are indebted to Milgram's study for this important, if unwelcome, information. However, although I am glad to know about Milgram's results, I doubt that I would have enjoyed being a subject in his experiment. Most of his subjects were emotionally drained by the experience, and some were visibly upset to discover how readily they had obeyed orders to deliver dangerous shocks to another person.

Milgram's study prompted psychology researchers to establish much clearer and stricter rules about what an experimenter can ethically ask a subject to do. Today, before the start of any psychological experiment—even the simplest and most innocuous—the experimenter is required to

submit a plan to a Human Subjects Committee that must either approve or reject the ethics of the experiment.

If anyone today submitted a proposal to conduct research similar to Milgram's study, the local Human Subjects Committee would almost certainly refuse permission. However, if the same procedures had been in place *at the time of Milgram's study*, would a committee have prohibited his study? The curious fact is that we aren't sure. Before Milgram's research, very few people expected his results to turn out as they did. Milgram had asked various psychologists and psychiatrists to predict the results; nearly all replied that only a rare psychopathic weirdo would press levers to deliver severe shocks. A Human Subjects Committee that shared this expectation might have foreseen little ethical difficulty with Milgram's study. The unforeseen ethical problem underscores just how surprising Milgram's results were.

SOMETHING TO THINK ABOUT

Here is one version of the experiment that Milgram never tried: At the start of the experiment, we announce that the teacher and the learner will trade places halfway through the experiment so that the previous "learner" will start delivering

shocks to the teacher. How do you think the teachers would behave then? What other changes in procedure can you imagine that might influence the degree of obedience?



THE MESSAGE

Fix the Situation, Not Human Nature

If you are in a crowded theater when a fire breaks out, you know you are supposed to file out quietly, because the risk of being trampled to death in a panic is greater than the danger from the fire itself. But what would you actually do? If a panic does develop, the first few to panic will get out safely; it would do you no good to keep calm if everyone else is about to panic. Because other people reason in the same way, before long someone does try to rush out, and then panic develops.

How could we prevent people from panicking? The best solution is not to tell people about the virtues of cooperation; it is to build more exits. Similarly, it is difficult to teach people to behave productively in any of the behavior traps presented in this chapter; the best advice is to avoid those situations. Also, if you have already been following someone's dangerous orders, as in Milgram's experiment, it is difficult to quit. The best time to quit is before the situation gets started. In short, instead of just finding the right act to take in each situation, it is important to choose one's situations.

S U M M A R Y

* *Behavior traps.* Certain situations—such as the dollar auction, the prisoner's dilemma, and the commons dilemma—pressure even intelligent and rational people into self-defeating behavior. (page 551)

* *Obedience.* Many people obey the orders of a person in authority even if they believe their actions will injure someone else. They are less likely to obey if they can see the person who would be injured. They are more likely to obey if other people are following orders without protest. (page 554)

Suggestions for Further Reading

- Brockner, J., & Rubin, J. Z. (1985). *Entrapment in escalating conflicts*. New York: Springer-Verlag. Describes research on the dollar auction and similar behavior traps.
- Milgram, S. (1975). *Obedience to authority*. New York: Harper & Row. Describes Milgram's classic experiments on obedience.

Terms

- behavior trap** a situation that almost forces people into self-defeating behaviors. (page 551)
- prisoner's dilemma** a situation where people must choose between an act that is beneficial to themselves but harmful to others and an act that is moderately beneficial to all. (page 552)
- commons dilemma** a situation where people who share a common resource tend to overuse it and therefore make it unavailable in the long run. (page 553)

Answer to Concept Check

16. In the early rounds, you know that any competitive move that you make is likely to provoke the other player to retaliate on the next move. You will gain more if both players cooperate than if you exchange retaliations. However, in the last round, you know that the other player will have no further opportunities to retaliate. (page 553)

Web Resources

Prisoners' Dilemma

serendip.brynmawr.edu/bb/pd.html

Play the Prisoners' Dilemma Game with Serendip. Win as much as you can!

Abnormalities and Therapies I: General Principles



15

★ MODULE 15.1

An Overview of Abnormal Behavior

Concepts of Normal and Abnormal Behavior

*Abnormal Behavior as a Culturally Determined
Phenomenon / The Origins of Abnormal Behavior*

The Classification and Prevalence

*of Psychological Disorders
Uses of DSM-IV / Criticisms of DSM-IV / DSM-IV's
Classifications / The Importance of Differential
Diagnosis*

★ MODULE 15.2

Psychotherapy

Psychoanalysis

Free Association / Dream Analysis / Transference

Behavior Therapy

*Behavior Therapy for Anorexia Nervosa / Behavior
Therapy for Bed-Wetting / Aversion Therapy*

Therapies That Focus on Thoughts and Beliefs

*Cognitive and Rational-Emotive Therapies /
Cognitive-Behavior Therapy*

Humanistic Therapy

Family Systems Therapy

General Trends in Psychotherapy

Brief Therapy / Group Therapy / Self-Help Groups

Evaluating the Effectiveness of Psychotherapy

*HOW EFFECTIVE IS PSYCHOTHERAPY?: WHAT'S THE
EVIDENCE? / Comparisons of Different Therapies and
Therapists / Is More Treatment Better? / Similarities
Among Psychotherapeutic Methods*

Advice for Potential Psychotherapy Clients

★ MODULE 15.3

Social and Legal Issues in the Treatment of People with Disorders

Mental Hospitals and Deinstitutionalization

Legal Issues in the Treatment of Disordered People

*Involuntary Commitment and Treatment / The Duty to
Protect / The Insanity Defense*

Predicting and Preventing Mental Illness

Over the past 4 months, George has struck and injured several dozen people, most of whom he hardly knew; 2 of them had to be sent to the hospital. George expresses no guilt, no regrets. He says he would attack every one of them again if he got the chance. What should society do with George?

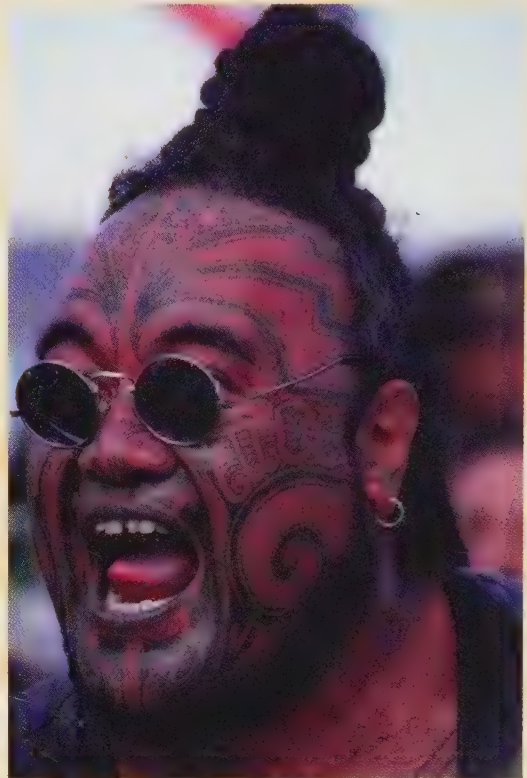
1. Send him to jail?
2. Commit him to a mental hospital?
3. Give him an award for being the best defensive player in the league?

Before you can answer these questions, you must know the context of George's behavior. Behavior that would seem normal at a party might seem bizarre in a business meeting. Behavior that earns millions for a rock singer might earn a trip to the mental hospital for a college professor. Behavior that is perfectly routine in one culture might be considered criminal in another.

Even when we know the context of someone's behavior, we may wonder whether it is "normal." Suppose your rich Aunt Tillie starts to pass out \$5 bills to strangers on the street corner and vows that she will keep on doing so until she has exhausted her entire fortune. Is she mentally ill? Should the court commit her to a mental hospital and turn her fortune over to you as her trustee?

A man claims to be Jesus Christ and asks permission to appear before the United Nations to announce God's message to the world. A psychiatrist is sure that he can relieve this man of his disordered thinking by giving him anti-psychotic drugs, but the man refuses to take the drugs and insists that his thinking is perfectly normal. Should we force

him to take the drugs, just ignore him, or place his address on the agenda of the United Nations?



What we consider normal behavior for a New Zealand Maori man might be considered abnormal for a business executive or a college professor.